

Introduction

Several well-known social theorists with illustrious profiles, such as Emile Durkheim, George Mead, John Dewey, and Jurgen Habermas, have typically encouraged people to get involved in their communities and become knowledgeable in community activism to facilitate the relationships that exists between individuals in social groups and organizations (Current, 2003, p. 164; Gutek, 1988, p.78). The philosopher Herbert Spencer, who adopted Darwin's theories of social evolution, had argued that an individual needs change to survive. This was emphasized in his famous phrase, "survival of the fittest", which implies that change is constant and only the fittest social structures survive and thrive (Marion, 2002, p. 10). In a similar manner, an organization must also adapt to change in order to survive. Organizations, such as colleges and universities, as well as business enterprises, have in the past decade undergone paradigm shifts that are having major repercussions with respect to constantly restructuring and changing to meet the needs of all of their stakeholders. A college organization such as Ohlone College is being forced to be more reflexive in its relationship to its environment and to also be responsible to multiple social forces rather than an autonomous site of higher learning (Robins & Webster, 2002, p. 45). Changes, such as those in the learning communities at Ohlone College, have forced organizations to rethink their core values for existence.

The importance of organization values

In the context of organizational changes, management, divisions, departments, faculty and the student body are a changing demography, which is an ongoing process. In this context, organizations must embrace constructive change in order to survive and grow. The reason for these changes must be compelling in order for them to be adopted and effective within these environments (Komives, 2003, p. 286). The stated mission, core values, and objectives of the

institution would be closely aligned to the changes in their environment to foster its visionary goals to move forward.

Clearer missions are essential to building a successful organization with respect to the pace of change needed to accomplish the vision of an integrated learning environment. A lot of organizations already have vision statements which are about what the organization might become. The purpose of a vision statement is to guide an organization to a place where everyone is working together toward the same ends. In the context of education, the vision provides lucid guidance for day-to-day decision making so that people are moving in the right direction. The authors Jacoby and Jones (1996) implied that having a vision is about shaping the future and understanding “why” organization exists. The mission provides the context for governance and decision-making processes in the way the school is managed. Vision and mission are the foundation of an organization. Strategic planning and meaningful goals are the foundations for good practices on how to achieve the organization’s mission. The defined core values describe how people ought to comport themselves to make the vision a reality. In the context of development, the values enforced are those core values that people hold dear, that reinforce peoples sense of belonging and purpose in the direction of their work, and that create a foundation for increased commitment to organizational objectives (Winston, Creamer & Miller, 2001, pp. 399-403).

How values should be developed in the organization

The values of an organization are set on governing principles on which the organization can always rely upon. The “how” challenges people within the organization to identify the specific attributes, behaviors, and commitments they must manifest in the execution of their responsibilities in order to make the vision a reality. This requires people to understand their role

in observing the agreed-upon 'rules of conduct'. As Rebore (2001) has pointed out, ethical behaviors are determined by good judgment, healthy experiences, humane societal conscience, and principle of proportionality. Professionalism, good attitudes, character, knowledge, skills, and actions are also considered significant factors in personal and interpersonal interactions in this environment (Marion, 2002, p.140). DuFour and Eaker (1998) suggested this approach:

1. Carefully review the school's vision statement.
2. Identify the attributes, behaviors, and commitments that must be demonstrated by the group in order to move the school closer to this vision.
3. Develop a draft of a statement of these attributes, behaviors, and commitments, limiting it to no more than 10 statements.
4. Arrange small-group meetings with colleagues to present task force findings, solicit feedback, and answer questions.
5. Revise initial draft as appropriate.
6. Continue small-group meetings and revisions until there is a strong consensus for the statements.
7. Present your finding to the entire staff and obtain its endorsement of the final product.

The leadership of an organization is entrusted with setting the standard for administrators, managers, faculty, students, and any other stakeholders, and challenges their members with the responsibilities. It begins with the leadership of an organization adhering to these governing principles by example.

Who should participate in the process of developing organizational values

As the authors Jacoby and Jones (1996) stated, "leadership needs to develop the skills of teamwork, consensus building, and group facilitation, as well as a belief that all in the

organization have something to contribute to the vision creation and implementation process” (p. 402). Establishing a shared vision for empowering everyone is essential to the vision building process. As Winston (2001) stated, it is the leadership of the organization’s responsibility to articulate the vision building process to the people in their organization. Nevertheless, vision clarity is essential to the success of the organization. The process of developing organizational values depends on the cooperation of all the people within the organization. Furthermore, authors Jacoby and Jones (1996) pointed out that vision is often taken for granted because it is an intangible objective best understood intuitively. The lasting consequences of reorganization are facilitating the continuous retraining of the members of individual and group responsibilities. In addition, adherence to the rules and core values of the organization requires monitoring.

How values should be communicated throughout the organization

Once the shared values are clearly defined, it takes the leadership at all levels in the organization to facilitate and work together with all the parties in the organization. A leader in the organization needs to assume the role of stewarding the values to keep them alive. It is important to keep discussing the shared values and guiding principles often as a reminder to all participants. Persons can collaboratively manage cohesive forms of communication and share input with other constituents, as well as demand uniform accountability. The shared values guide standard communication and the decision-making processes.

How values should be maintained throughout the organization

By empowering the people in the organization, leaders at all levels will help facilitate good and lasting relationships with all those involved in the organization to execute their shared vision. All the people in the organization are joint participants in the process of developing and maintaining defined organizational values. The structure of the organization is important in

sustaining the values through its adoption of training, planning, and equipping people throughout the organization to live according to its shared vision and mission imperatives. The theorist Abraham Maslow (1954) talked about the human needs (physiological, safety, belongingness and love, esteem, and self-actualization), saying that people and organizations need each other to execute the shared vision (Bolman & Deal, 2003, p. 117).

Industrialist Frederick Taylor, considered the father of Scientific Management, argued the theory that “one best system” is based on a hierarchical structure of an organization to splinter the tasks of problem solving. He goes on to say greater efficiency within the organization is gained when the workers are working towards the same goals (Marion, 2002, p. 22).

Ohlone College:

The Learning Communities

Two years ago, Ohlone College launched the learning communities initiative, a major transformation in how the college thinks about teaching and learning. Learning communities intentionally restructured the curriculum in ways that bring students, faculty and disciplines together in more integrated and meaningful ways. This theoretical framework was based on the work of Senge (1996). He developed the concepts and applications of learning organizations and applied these ideas to a college model.

In a learning college model, faculty shape their teaching around the ways of thinking they want their students to develop and they design assessments that require students to demonstrate their deep thinking and understanding through application and use.

The “learning college paradigm” seeks to create a learner-centered institution where all stakeholders pursue life long learning and commit to innovation, creativity and risk taking. The theoretical base for learning communities is about making deep cognitive, neural and social

connections, and that learners learn best in collaborative learning environments where they actively engage in the social construction knowledge (Merriam & Caffarella, 1999, p. 69).

How values should be developed in the learning communities

Learning communities are a major, broad based innovation that, because of its alteration of the traditional curriculum, can be thought of as the catalyst for transforming the entire institution and advancing the “learning college paradigm”. Learning communities unify the campus culture by bringing together professionals in different units of the campus that have distinct missions such as librarians, educational technologists, IT staff, counselors, to collaborate with educators and students in learning communities. Ohlone College (2005) core values include:

1. Support Conditions: The learning community finds resources, creates schedules and generates structures that reduce isolation for its member; it runs on policies that encourage greater autonomy, foster collaboration/communication, and provide for staff development.
2. Shared Personal Practice: Faculty and staff find help, support and trust as a result of developing productivity relationships with each other. Faculty and administrators tolerate (even encourage) debate, discussion and disagreement. They are comfortable sharing successes and failures. They praise and recognize triumphs, and offer empathy and support for each other’s troubles.

Who should participate in the process of developing learning communities

As true learning communities, Ohlone College involves all people in the organization (faculty, staff, students, and stakeholders) in their decision making process. Faculty and staff will have the authority and the associated responsibility to provide the leadership it takes to continually build community, improve instruction, and increase student access. Ohlone College

encourages and supports high level of faculty and staff leadership as well as students in the learning communities.

How values should be communicated throughout the learning communities

Learning communities are structures that intentionally merge the academic and social function of the undergraduate experience. They promote learning environments that integrate the ways the students learn, within and outside of the classroom, and enable collaborations and partnerships between professionals in student affairs and educators. In addition, learning communities are structures that promote high levels of interaction and collaboration between students and faculty, and student to student. Online Learning technologies such as course management systems, synchronous, and asynchronous online communication tools can greatly enhance learning communities by extending student to student interactions beyond the classroom and in enabling collaborative learning online. Ohlone College communicates with the learning communities by actively engaging in ongoing open communication with faculty and other members of the college. All the people in the organization need to assume the role of stewarding the values to keep them alive.

How values should be maintained throughout the learning communities

By empowering the people in the organization, administrators, staff, faculty, and students will help facilitate good and lasting relationships with all those involved in the organization to execute their shared vision. All people in the organization are joint participants in the process of developing and maintaining defined organizational values. The desire for this type of learning, and for all stakeholders in a campus community to think and act systemically, is what will trigger the necessary collaborative partnerships between academic and student affairs divisions that will

enable students to see the academic and social dimensions of the college as integrated. Ohlone College maintains the learning communities by:

1. Sharing information freely and helping others utilize their talents to the fullest
2. Respecting the right of others to a safe and free learning environment
3. Being flexible and open to many ideas about how people learn.
4. Having all the people in the organization bound by a professional standard of ethics
5. Having a citizen of the community responsible for both fostering the commitment to life long learning and for participating in the community.
6. Assuming responsibility for their learning and the learning of others around them
7. Being willing to take turns in leadership
8. Maintaining rules and regulations for instructors: be prepared, know your subject, and prepare your classes.
9. Maintaining rules and regulations for students: be prepared, do the homework, take the necessary prerequisites, and be attentive.
10. Maintaining rules and regulations for administrators: enforce the rules but otherwise get out of the way.

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